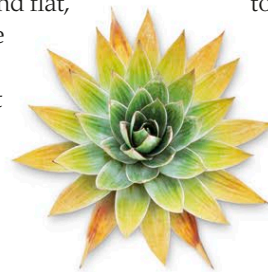




The Guiana Highlands

A spectacular area of South America with astonishing flat-topped mountains and some of the world's most impressive waterfalls

The Guiana Highlands extend across the northern part of South America, occupying much of southern Venezuela, as well as parts of Guyana and northern Brazil. The Highlands are famous for their ancient and magnificent flat-topped mountains called tepuis. The word *tepui* means “house of the gods” in the language of the local Pemon people. Many of these landforms appear otherworldly, with their sheer cliffs and flat, vegetated, seemingly inaccessible tops. Some of the most famous include Auyan Tepui, Mount Roraima, and Kukenan Tepui. Mount Roraima is said to have inspired the Scottish author Sir Arthur Conan Doyle to write his novel *The Lost World*, about the discovery of a remote plateau where prehistoric creatures still exist.



Auyan Tepui and Angel Falls

Auyan Tepui is the largest of the tepuis, with a surface area of 270 square miles (700 square km), partly covered by cloud forest. The world's highest uninterrupted waterfall, Angel Falls, drops from a cleft in its summit. The Churun River, a tributary of the Orinoco, flows over the falls, descending a total of 3,212 ft (979 m) to the valley floor. The main plunge, of 2,648 ft (807 m), is followed by a series of sloping cascades and rapids.

◁ ENDEMIC FLORA

A long period of isolation means that many animal and plant species, such as the example from the genus *Orectanthe* shown here, have evolved on tepui summits and are found only on tepuis.

The **rock** from which **Mount Roraima** was **carved out** was laid down about **1.8 billion years ago**



△ LOST WORLD

One of the highest tepuis, Mount Roraima is surrounded by stepped cliffs up to 1,300 ft (400 m) high and is the source of several rivers.

◁ LONG DROP

In Angel Falls' uppermost thousand feet, the water barely makes contact with the sheer sandstone cliffs behind.

HOW TEPUIS FORM

The Guiana Highlands were once an extensive sandstone plateau. Over a period of some 1.5 billion years, weak sections of the plateau were eroded away by rivers and streams, leaving behind the tepuis.

